

Northwind Traders

Employee & IT Handbook — 2026 Edition

This handbook is the single source of truth for Northwind Traders policies covering remote work, IT security, equipment, time off, expenses, onboarding, and support escalation. It is intended for use as a reference document and, in this exercise, as the knowledge base for a retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) chatbot.

1. Company Overview

Northwind Traders is a logistics and supply-chain software company headquartered in Portland, Oregon, with satellite offices in Austin, Texas and Lisbon, Portugal. The company was founded in 2014 and employs approximately 480 people across three departments: Engineering, Operations, and Customer Success.

The fiscal year at Northwind Traders runs from February 1 to January 31. All employees report to a department lead, who reports to one of three Vice Presidents.

2. Remote Work Policy

Northwind Traders operates a hybrid-first model. Employees are expected to work from an approved office location a minimum of 2 days per week. Fully remote arrangements require written approval from a Vice President and are reviewed every 6 months.

Employees working remotely outside their home country for more than 30 consecutive days must notify the People Operations team at least 10 business days in advance, due to tax and legal compliance requirements.

3. VPN and Security Access

All employees must connect through the Northwind VPN (NorthwindConnect) when accessing internal systems from outside an office network. NorthwindConnect sessions automatically time out after 45 minutes of inactivity and must be re-authenticated using multi-factor authentication (MFA).

VPN access requests are provisioned by the IT Security team and typically take 1 business day to activate for new hires. Contractors are issued VPN access valid for a maximum of 90 days, after which it must be renewed by their sponsoring manager.

Employees who fail MFA authentication 5 times within a 24-hour window will have their account automatically locked and must contact the IT Help Desk to regain access.

4. Password and Data Security Policy

Passwords for all Northwind systems must be at least 14 characters long and rotated every 120 days. Reusing any of the last 8 passwords is not permitted.

Customer data classified as Tier 1 (personally identifiable information) may only be stored in the approved Northwind data warehouse and must never be exported to personal devices or third-party cloud storage such as personal Google Drive or Dropbox accounts.

5. Equipment and Hardware

New employees receive a standard equipment package consisting of a laptop, a docking station, and a monitor, shipped to arrive no later than 3 business days before their start date. Engineering employees may additionally request a second monitor through the IT portal.

Equipment is refreshed on a 3-year cycle. Employees who damage equipment through negligence are responsible for a \$150 deductible toward replacement; damage due to manufacturing defects is covered in full under warranty.

6. Paid Time Off (PTO) Policy

Full-time employees accrue 18 days of PTO per year during their first 3 years of employment. After 3 years of continuous service, accrual increases to 23 days per year. Part-time employees (working fewer than 30 hours per week) accrue PTO on a pro-rated basis calculated from the 18-day baseline.

Employees may carry over a maximum of 5 unused PTO days into the following calendar year. Any unused days beyond that are forfeited on January 31, the last day of the fiscal year.

Separately, all employees receive 10 paid company holidays per year and up to 5 paid sick days, which do not draw from the PTO balance.

7. Expense Reimbursement

Employees may submit expense reports through the Concur portal within 60 days of the expense date. Reports submitted after 60 days require Vice President approval to be processed.

Standard meal reimbursement while traveling for business is capped at \$75 per day domestically and \$110 per day for international travel. Client entertainment expenses require pre-approval from a department lead regardless of amount.

Home office equipment for approved remote employees is reimbursable up to \$500 per calendar year, separate from the standard equipment package issued by IT.

8. Onboarding Process

New hire onboarding at Northwind Traders spans the first 2 weeks of employment. Day 1 includes an orientation session with People Operations, IT account provisioning, and a welcome lunch with the employee's team.

Every new employee is assigned an onboarding buddy from within their department for the first 30 days. New managers additionally complete a mandatory Manager Foundations training within their first 45 days.

9. IT Support Escalation

IT Help Desk tickets are triaged into three severity levels. Severity 1 (system-wide outage) tickets receive a response within 30 minutes, 24 hours a day. Severity 2 (individual access or hardware issue) tickets receive a response within 4 business hours. Severity 3 (general questions or requests) tickets receive a response within 2 business days.

If a Severity 1 or Severity 2 ticket is not resolved within its response window, it is automatically escalated to the on-call IT Security lead. Employees can reach the Help Desk at extension 4100 or via the #it-help Slack channel.

10. Performance Review Cycle

Formal performance reviews occur twice per year, in March and September. New employees receive an additional 90-day check-in review conducted by their direct manager.

Compensation adjustments resulting from the September review cycle take effect on November 1. Promotions may be submitted for review during either cycle but are formally approved only during the March cycle.